

Nomad King

Genre: Tactical board game
Version: 28.05.2026
Janusch Rentenatus

Players: 2
Age: 12 – 99
Duration: about 15 minutes

Components:

- 13 white, 13 black and 8 grey/brown large stones (similar to checkers / mills pieces)
- 2 small yellow dice (motivation markers)
- 2 pawns (e.g. orange and green)
- 1 game board
- These rules



Background story:

The game board represents the wide open steppe. The large stones are the camp sites of the nomadic families. These camps can be founded by your own supporters, by your opponent, or by neutral clans that wander through the land. Each pawn represents a prince who strives for the crown. A prince is crowned king once he has crossed the board and entered the palace on the opposite side. On his journey, a prince may only move from one camp to the next adjacent camp that is either friendly or neutral. He may never cross the empty steppe (empty board spaces) and he may never pass through hostile camps. As a player you must therefore build a kind of bridge of camps across the steppe to lead your prince to the palace. But whenever there is **overpopulation** or **underpopulation**, the nomad tribes will pack their tents and move on. Your opponent will use this to sabotage the connection your prince relies on.

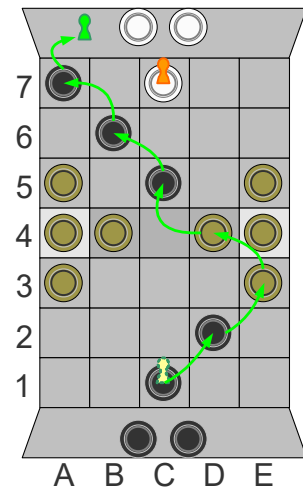
Objective of the game:

The primary objective of the game is to guide your own prince across the board. 

Your prince moves like the chess king: only from one neighbouring field to another, but he may step only on your own and on neutral camp stones.

His destination is the palace on the opposite edge of the board.

If the path is perfectly prepared, the shortest possible route takes 7 steps.

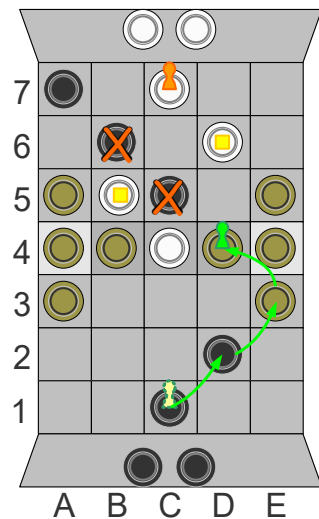
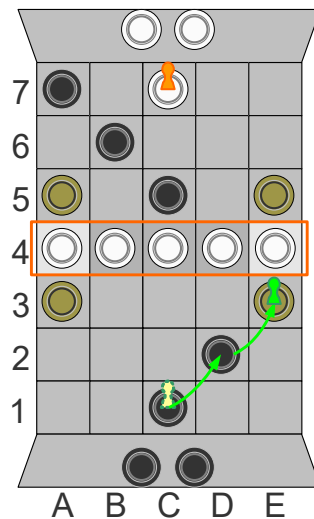
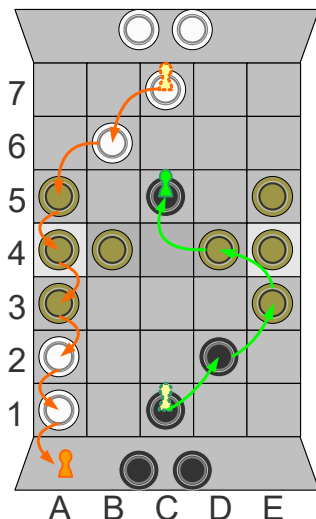


Your opponent will try to reach the palace faster,

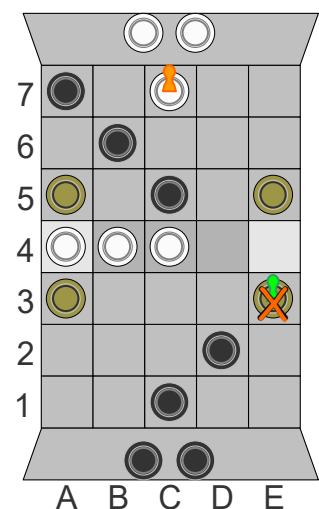
to block your way,



or to break apart the camp bridge that carries your prince. 



If a player manages to remove the camp on which the opponent's prince is currently standing, that prince is immediately lost and the attacker wins the game at once.



Setup:

Place the game board in the centre of the table.

One player takes the white camp stones and the orange prince pawn, the other player takes the black camp stones and the green prince pawn. Set up all stones and both pawns according to one chosen starting layout.

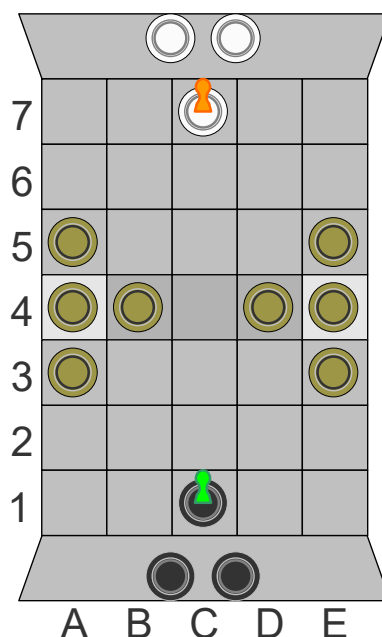
Standard starting layout:

Additional starting layouts are described at the end of the rulebook.

The spaces occupied by the two game pieces represent the palace. The pieces remain there throughout the game.

Course of play:

The players take turns. Black plays the first turn.



Two phases:

On their turn, a player must go through the following two phases in exactly this order, or skip them:

1) Either **demolish** threatened camp sites (see chapter "Demolition" and chapter "Movement") or **move** their prince.

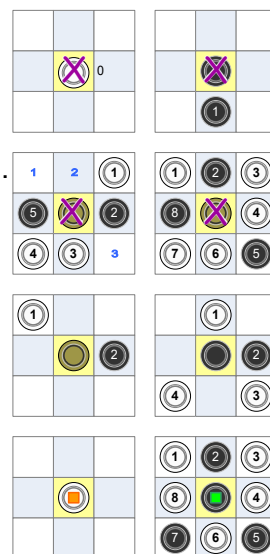
2) Either **build** new camp sites (see chapter "Construction" and chapter "Movement") or **move** their prince.

Combinations: First Demolition, then Construction; First Demolition, then Movement; First Movement, then Construction; First Pass, then Construction; Movement and then Movement again; Single Movement only; Complete Pass (skip both phases).

X Demolition of camp sites:

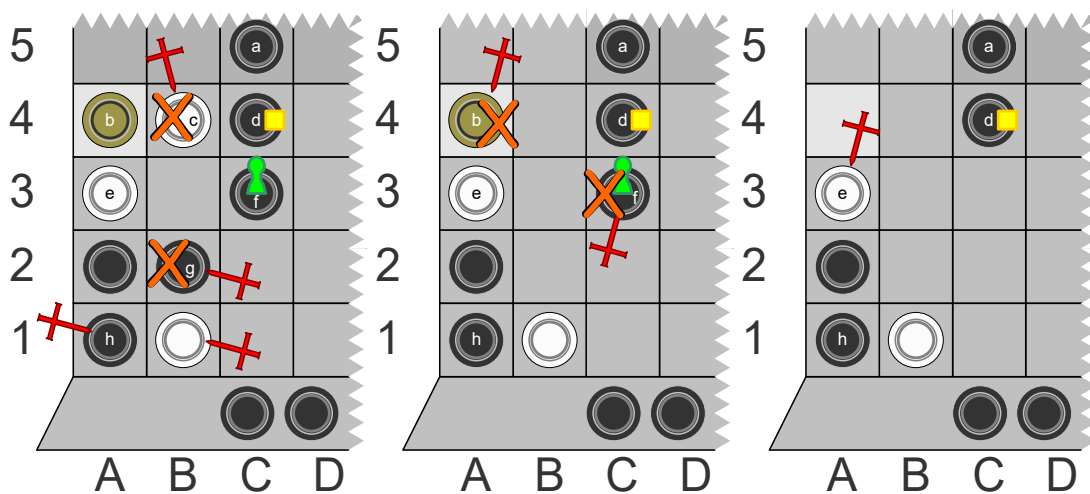
A camp site has up to 8 neighbouring fields: two horizontal, two vertical and four diagonal. If a player chooses Demolition in the first phase of their turn, the following rules apply:

- At the bottom and top edges of the board there is one palace each. A palace always counts as two neighbours.
- The player may demolish their own camp sites, neutral camp sites (shown in brown) and camp sites of the opponent.
- Reinforced camp sites with 2 stones stacked on top of each other count as 2 neighbours,
- Reinforced camp sites with 3 stones count as 3 neighbours, and so on.
- A camp site that has only **1 or 0 neighbours** may be demolished because of **underpopulation**.
- A camp site that has **5, 6, 7 or more neighbours** may be demolished because of **overpopulation**.
- Reinforced camp sites (stone stacks) are always removed completely as a whole stack.
- There is no obligation to use all possible demolitions.
- The inhabitants of a camp site with exactly 2, 3 or 4 neighbours feel comfortable. Such a camp site may not be demolished.



- A camp site that carries a yellow motivation die is safe and may not be demolished. 
- Demolition can trigger chains of further demolitions. After each removed single stone (camp site) or removed stone stack (reinforced camp site), the situation on the board is evaluated again. The player may perform this chain of demolitions in any order of their choice within their turn. The chain is finite; the opponent has no veto and cannot interrupt it.
- If a player demolishes the camp site on which the opponent's prince is standing, that prince is removed from the game immediately. The active player wins the game at once.
- The demolished stones are returned as follows: Demolished stones of the opponent are given back to the opponent. Demolished own camp stones are taken back by the active player. Demolished neutral stones are removed from the game entirely..

Example: White to move:



First and second step: The camp sites c on B4 and g on B2 are threatened because they have 5 single-stone neighbours. The camp site h on A1 is threatened because it has 5 neighbours (3 camp stones plus 2 palace neighbours counted in general), and the stone on B1 is threatened in the same way. However, the White player is not forced to demolish the camp site h on A1. White chooses to demolish, due to overpopulation, their own camp site c on B4 and the camp site g on B2.

Third and fourth step, same turn: After these demolitions, the camp site h on A1 now has only 4 neighbours and is safe. The camp sites b on A4 and f on C3 now have only 1 neighbour each and are demolished because of underpopulation. During this demolition chain White also removes the camp site that carries the opponent's prince and therefore wins the game.

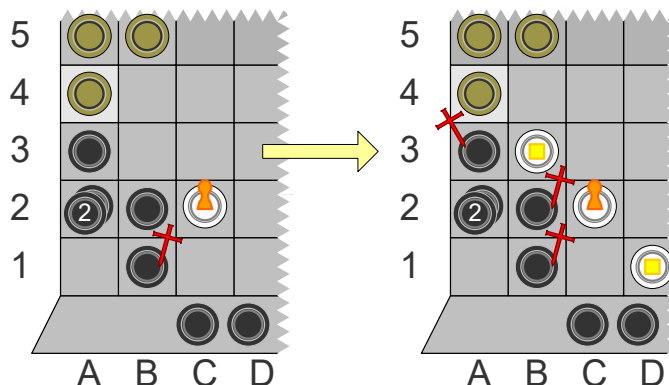
Construction of camp sites:

 To build new camp sites, the following rules apply:

-  The player may place up to 2 stones (camp sites) on any empty field on the board (new camp) or on an existing own or neutral stone (reinforced camp)
-  Each newly placed or newly reinforced camp for the next round may be secured with an extra motivation marker: a small yellow die placed on top of the camp. 
- Existing motivation markers are taken off their old camp sites and reused when securing new or reinforced camp sites. There is no general supply; motivation markers must be used strategically.
- The player may also found a new camp site in an area where it would normally not survive due to **overpopulation** or **underpopulation**.

- The two new stones may immediately be stacked on top of each other to form a reinforced camp site. A stone stack receives only a single motivation marker; any second marker must be left wherever he is.
- It is allowed to reinforce the camp site underneath the prince. In that case, however, the protective extra motivation marker may not be placed on the prince's camp site. One marker must be left wherever he is.
- Each player has a maximum of 13 camp stones available. If all 13 camp stones of a player are already on the board, stones must first be demolished before new camp sites can be built.

Example: White to move:



In this board fragment, the white prince is standing on C2. The White player places two new camp sites and secures them with small yellow dice as extra motivation. The new camp site on B3 has 6 neighbours (A2 is a double stone stack) and would normally be overpopulated, but it is currently protected by its motivation marker.

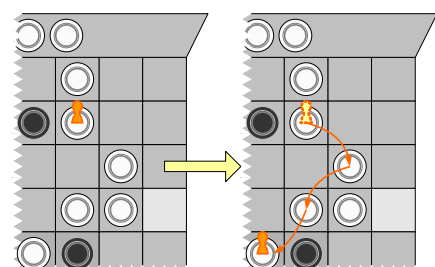
In the next turn, White may attack the black camp sites on B1, B2 and A3 due to overpopulation. Until then, the camp site on B3 remains threatened but will not be demolished while its motivation marker is in place.

Movement of the princes:

- A prince moves only across neighbouring fields, like a chess king.
- A movement is valid only across own and neutral camp sites. A prince may not move across empty board fields and may not move across camp sites of the opponent.
- Within a single movement, a prince may move up to 3 steps.
- A prince may not end his movement on a neutral field that is occupied by the opponent's prince.
- A prince may move across his own palace but may not end his movement on a palace field. In this way, with just two steps he could move from one corner across his palace directly into the opposite corner of the board.
- If a prince ends his movement on a field that carries an extra motivation marker, the marker is removed from that field.

Example: White to move:

White moves the prince up to 3 fields in one movement.

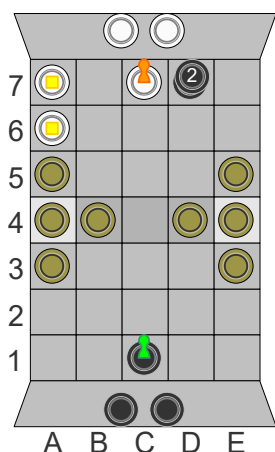


End of the game:

The game ends immediately in one of the following situations: A player loses their prince on the board (for example through demolition of the camp site the prince is standing on). A player successfully guides their prince across the board, enters the palace on the opposite side and celebrates the coronation there.

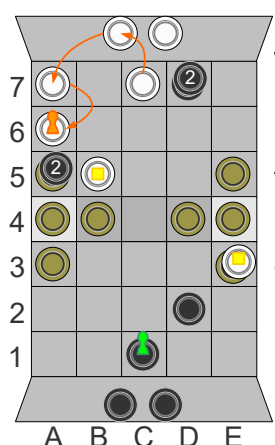
Example: opening sequence:

In the standard starting layout, no own and no neutral camp stones are in reach of the black prince. In phase 1 Black can neither move the prince nor demolish any camp sites. In phase 2 Black can construct new camp sites but still cannot move the prince. Black attacks White on D7: the camp site of the white prince on C7 now has 4 neighbours (2 palace neighbours plus 2 black camp sites) and is close to overpopulation.



White's turn:

In phase 1 White still cannot move the prince and cannot demolish any camp sites from the starting position. In phase 2 White can build, but still cannot move the prince, and starts to prepare an escape route.

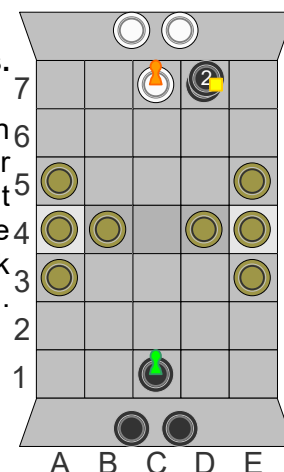


White's turn:

In phase 1 White could move the prince across the own palace and the field A7 onto the own camp site on A6.

In phase 2 White blocks the black bridge and repairs the own connection of camp sites.

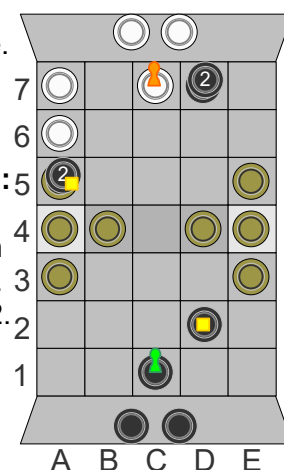
Black begins.



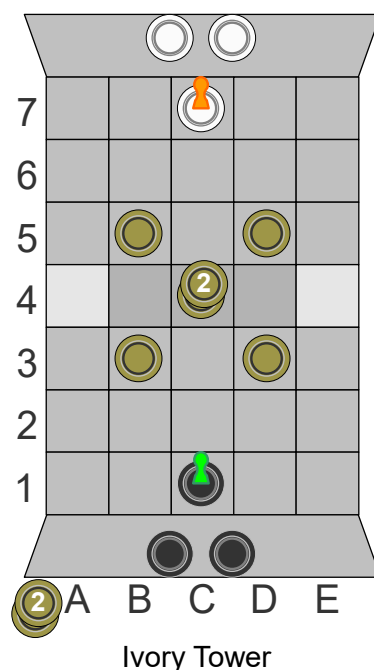
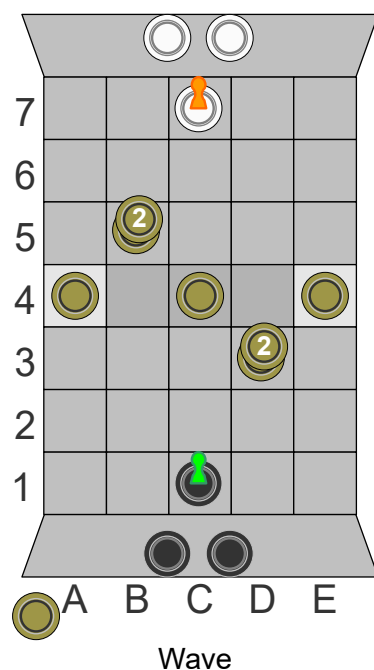
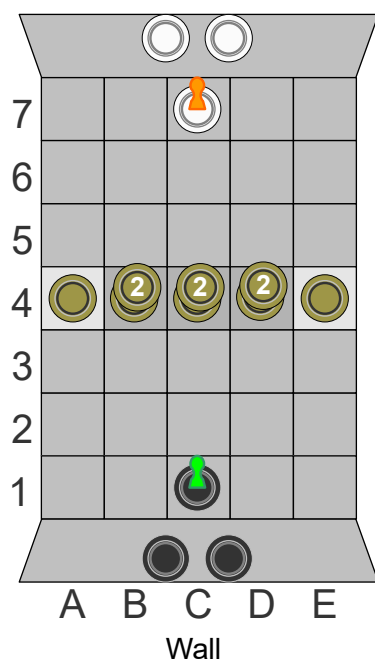
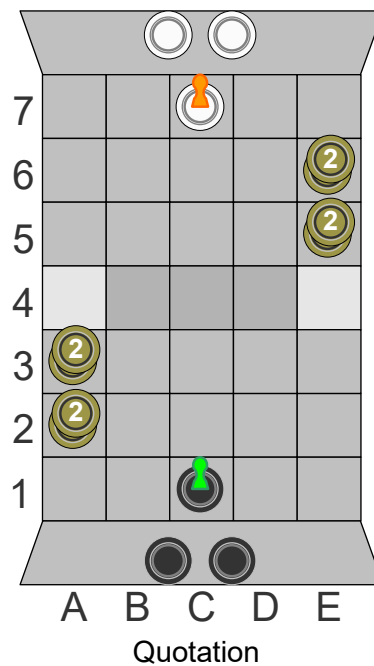
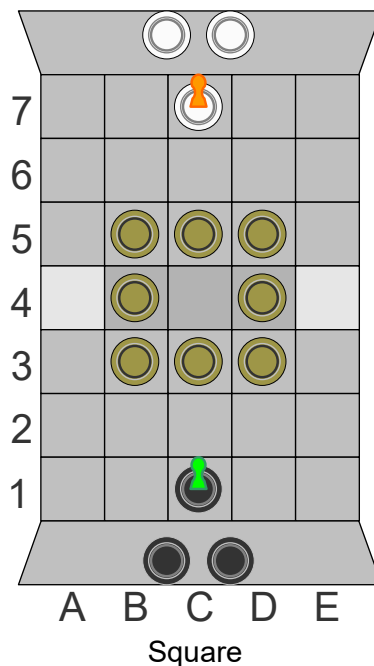
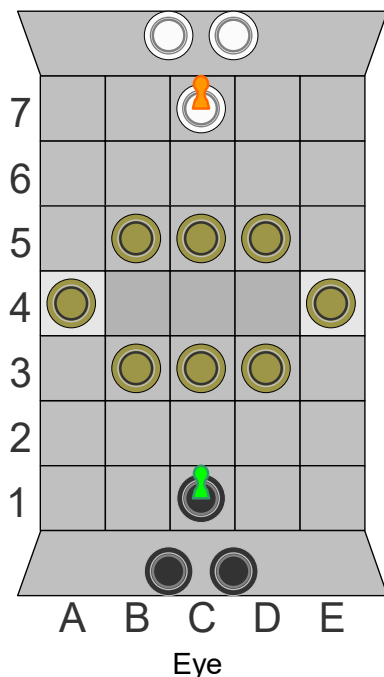
Black's turn:

In phase 1 Black still cannot demolish and cannot move the prince.

In phase 2 Black blocks on A5 and builds on D2.



Alternative starting layouts:



Design background:

The game Nomad King was inspired by John Horton Conway's "Game of Life" (1970). Conway's system is based on a two-dimensional cellular automaton, a simple yet influential model within the automata theory developed by Stanisław Marcin Ulam. In Nomad King, the automatic birth of new stones is replaced by the tactical decisions of the players. Unlike in a strict automaton, the "death" of a camp site is not mandatory: even colonies that would be doomed under the usual population rules may survive if a player chooses not to demolish them. Chains of demolition moves can be used deliberately to create complex board states and dramatic turning points in the game. The abstract theory of the Game of Life is extended by an overarching objective and a narrative frame: two rival princes trying to cross a living landscape of nomad camps to reach the crown.

Quick Reference Guide

Schwarz beginnt :



1. Either demolish X

underpopulation: 0 , 1

overpopulation: 5, 6, 7 and more

Camp site with exactly 2, 3 or 4 neighbours feel comfortable

A camp site that carries a yellow motivation die is safe ■

OR move


 0...3


2. Either build up to 2

One or two newly set-up camp site are secured with extra motivation (the small cubes).

Place on empty spaces or on your own or neutral camps .

OR move


 0...3


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